Research Methods in Social Psychology

Objectives of chapter 2



- Process of scientific research
- Research methods
- Role of theory in research
- Research ethics and challenges

Science

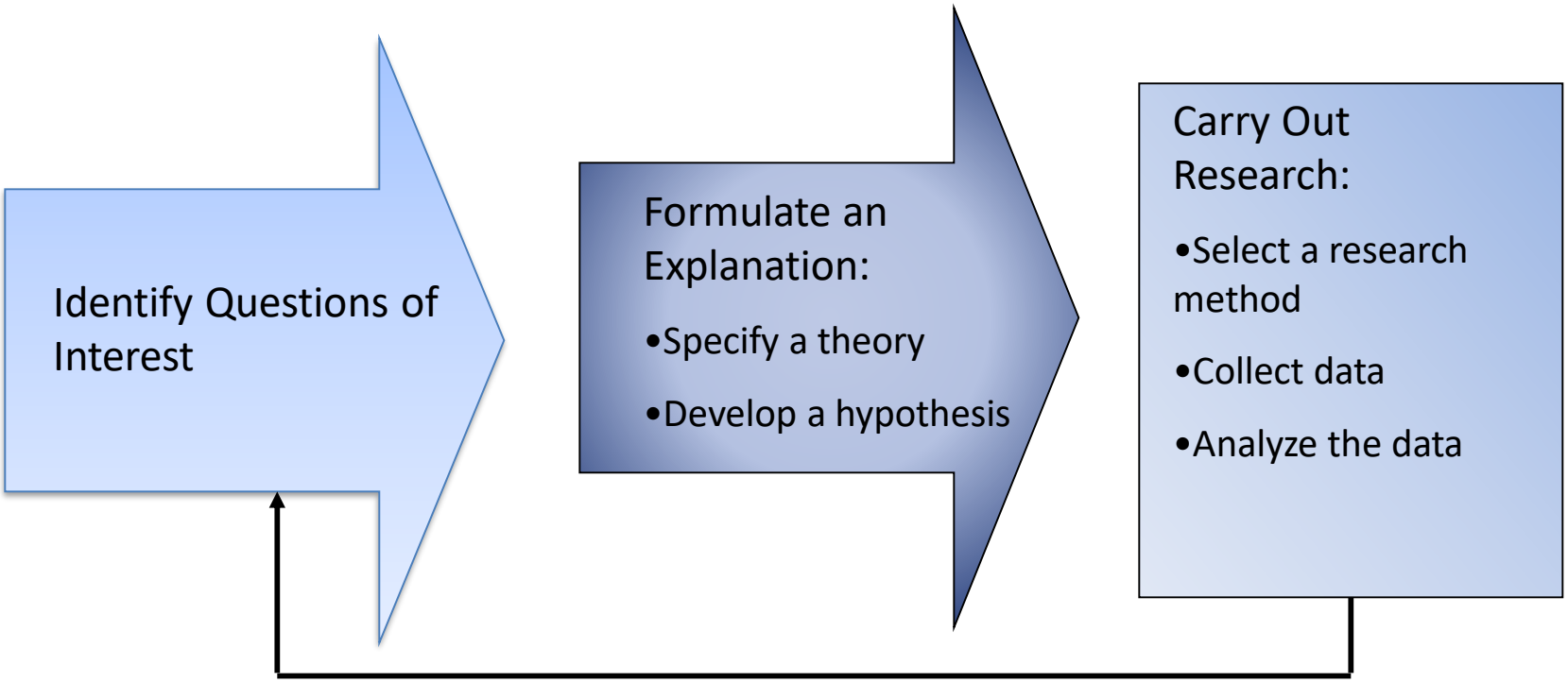
- Accuracy: a commitment of gathering and evaluating information
- Objectivity: evaluating information in a manner that is free from biasness
- Skepticism: accept findings as actual
- Open minded: a commitment to changing one's views

Scientific Method



- The approach used by psychologists to ***systematically*** acquire knowledge and understanding about behavior and other phenomena of interest

Scientific Method: The Process



Scientific Method

- Theories
  - Broad explanations and predictions concerning phenomena of interest
- Hypothesis
  - A prediction stated in a way that allows it to be tested



Research Methods

- Systematic observation
  - carefully observing behavior as it occurs.

Naturalistic observation

- Observation of naturally occurring behavior without intervention



Research Methods

- Survey research
  - A sample of people are asked a series of questions about their behavior, thoughts, and attitudes in order to represent a larger population.



Research Methods

Correlational research

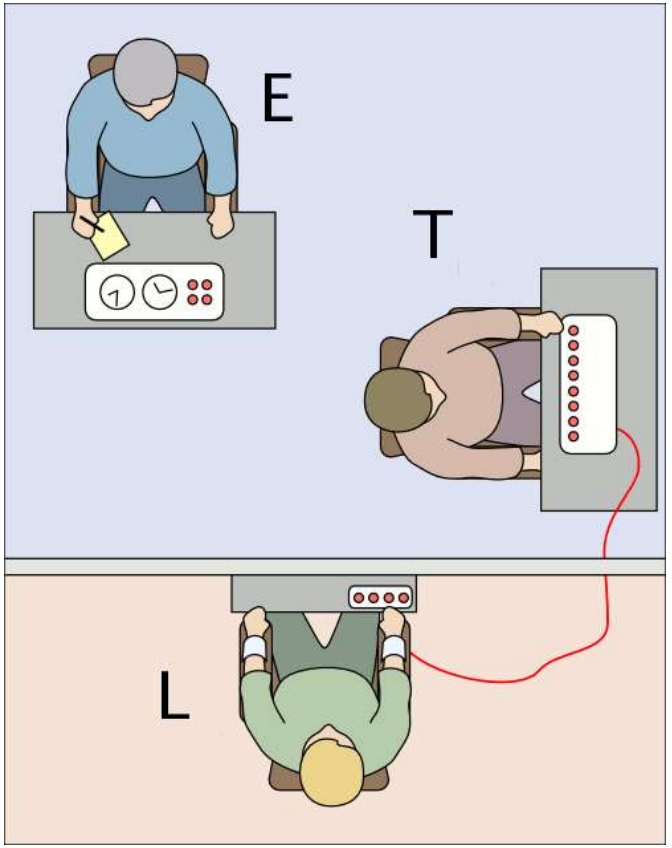
– The relationship between one set of variables is examined to determine whether they are associated, or "correlated"

– Ranges from +1 (positive) to -1 (negative)



Research Methods

- Experimental Research
  - The relationship between two (or more) variables is investigated by deliberately producing a change in one variable in a situation and observing the effects of that change on other aspects of the situation



Experimental Research

- Independent variable - The variable that is manipulated by the experimenter.
- Dependent variable - The variable that is measured and is expected to change as a result of changes caused by the experimenter's manipulation of the independent variable.

- Confounding variable - Where two or more independent variables co vary in such a way that it is impossible to know which has caused the effect.
- Mediating variable - A variable that is affected by an independent variable and then influences a dependent variable. It helps explain why or how specific variables influence social behavior or thought.

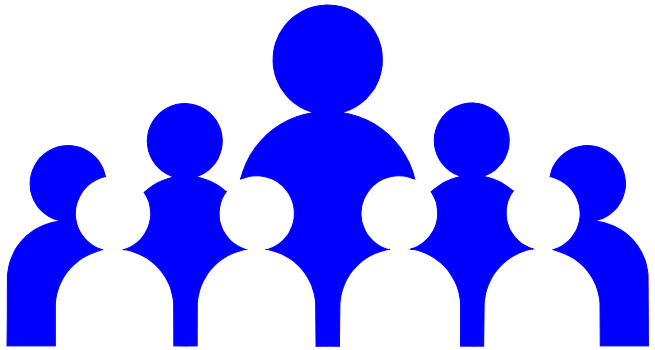
Experimental Research

- Random assignment to condition
  - Participants are assigned to different experimental groups or "conditions" on the basis of chance and chance alone.

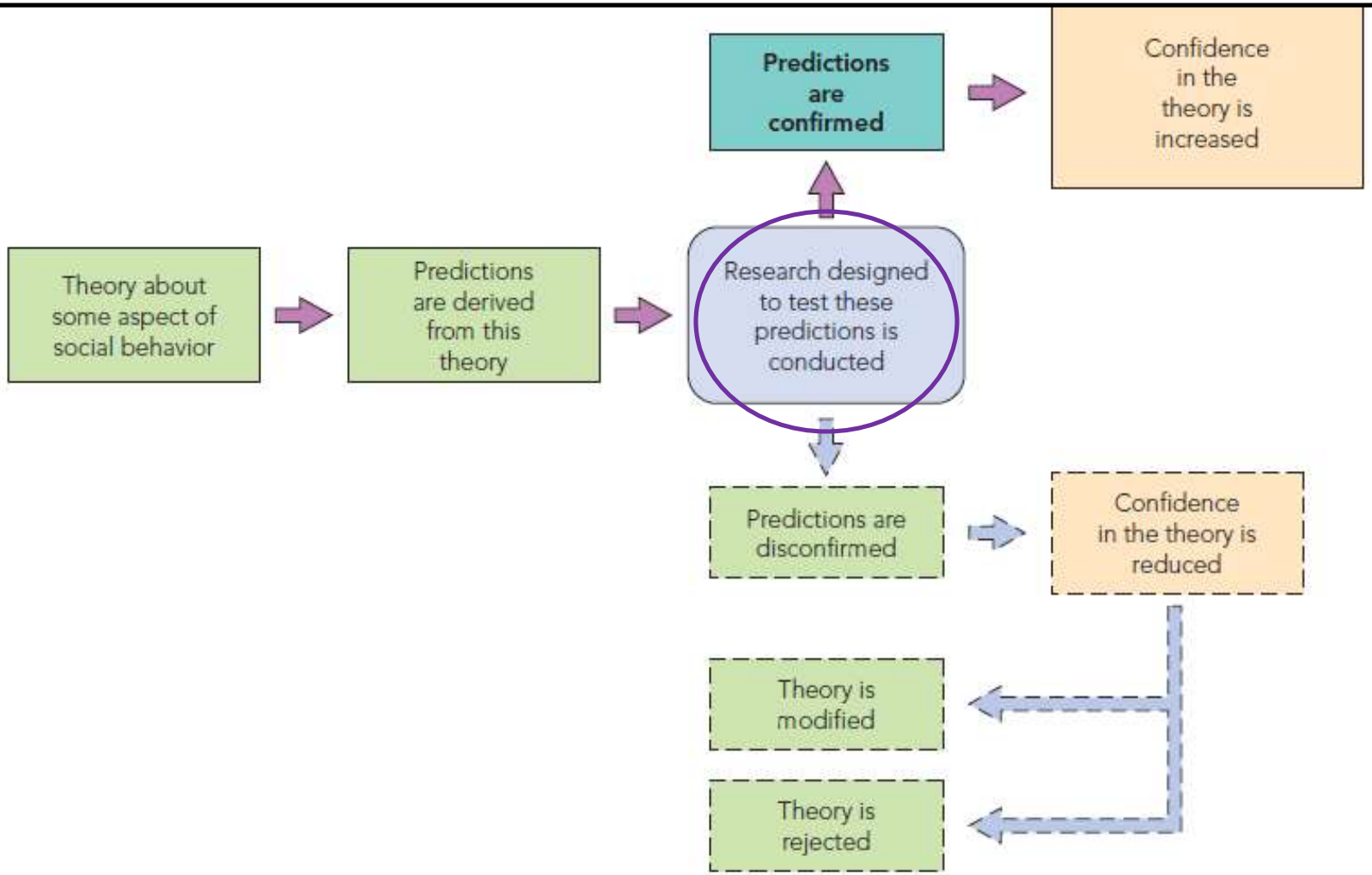


Experimental Research

- Experimental manipulation
  - The change that an experimenter deliberately produces in a situation
- Experimental group
  - Any group receiving a treatment
- Control group
  - A group that receives no treatment



Role of Theory



Experimental Research

- The Broken Window theory experiment, Keizer et al., 2008.

- When people observe others violating a social norm or a legitimate rule, are they more likely to violate other norms or rules, and thus disorder spreads?

- Independent variable – Environment
- Dependent variable – number of people who violate.

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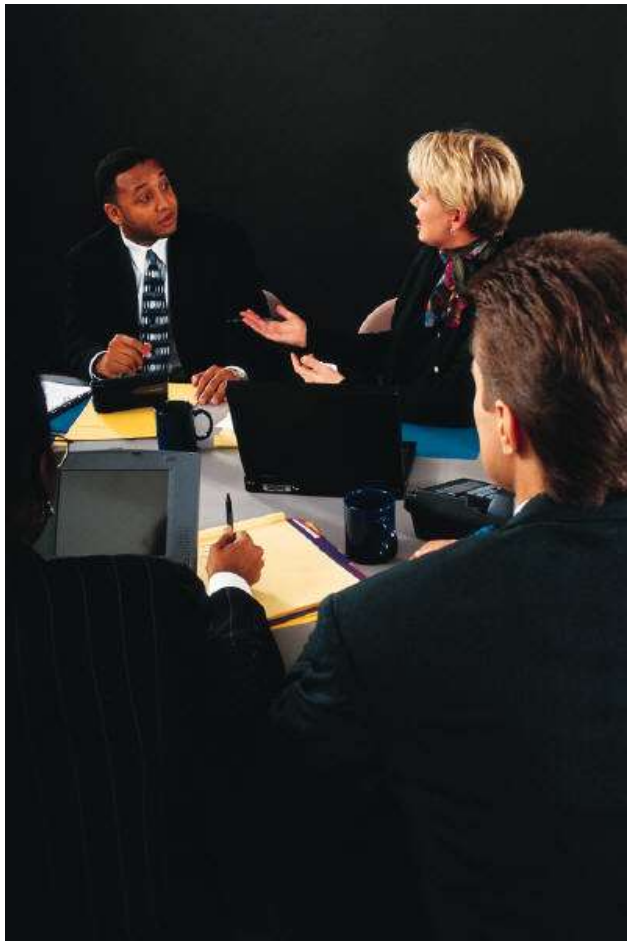
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Source: Keizer, K., S. Lindenberg, and L. Steg. "The Spreading of Disorder." *Science* 322, no. 5908: 1681-5.
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Research Challenges: Ethics

- Protection of participants from physical and mental harm
- The right of participants to privacy regarding their behavior
- The assurance that participation in research is completely voluntary
- The necessity of informing participants about the nature of procedures prior to participation in the experiment
- Informed consent
  - Deception and debriefing



Reference

Text book

- Baron, R.A. & Branscombe, N.R. (2012). *Social Psychology.* (13th ed.). Pearson Education, Inc.